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THE LION PRINCE

A spectacular assembly election win ended a long political winter for Kashmir and his party, the National Conference. But Omar Abdullah now faces crucial tests—that of meeting great expectations and holding his own with the Centre till J&K gets its statehood back

By Kaleem Geelani

It had been a long hiatus for Kashmiri *netas*, much of the stock-in-trade of their political life had been in suspended animation for far too long. A decade had passed since the last election. There hadn't been a regular government for eight years. And after August 2019, when the old bridge of Article 370 was pulled down and the state shrunk in size and in formal conception, even ceasing to be a state, everything went into deep freeze—the entire infinitude of everyday interaction with the public sphere. Omar Abdullah, former chief minister (2008-2014), was among those who also felt that other effect: presaging the abnormal hibernation imposed by Covid-19, their turfs were abridged to the confines of homes. It was a total political lockdown.

But 2024 came as a year of change. First, the Lok Sabha poll in April-May. Then the long-awaited assembly election in October. Lifeblood flowed back to normal; Kashmiri politicians plunged headlong into the season of political rebirth. And as all the hectic parleying, alliance-making, jousts, scrimmages and voting drew to a close, one man stood taller than others: Omar, the grandson of a man who had a leonine aura in these parts, his own street cred burnished by 232 days of house arrest and a general tone of oppositional politics.

The NC government's holy grail is restoration of statehood. Its demand both reflects the street, and helps deflect any anger

The general election was a mixed bag for Omar. As vice-president of the National Conference (NC), he led his party to victories in two of the three seats it contested, but he suffered a humiliating defeat, by over 200,000 votes, in Baramulla—that too to a maverick independent of separatist lineage, Abdul 'Engineer' Rashid. At first, a dejected Omar thought of sitting out the assembly polls; it took some persuasion for him to change his mind. It was like a minefield out there: a flurry of independents, emboldened by Rashid's win, even former militants under the virtual umbrella of the banned Muslim League, not to speak of an alphabet